



THIS BRONZE HELMET PROTECTED THE GLADIATOR'S HEAD, THROAT, AND NECK.

The emperor-gladiator

You'd be shocked if you saw your country's leader fighting in public—unless, that is, you were at a gladiatorial contest in Rome in the late 2nd century CE. If you'd gone to the Colosseum,

which was the place to see the heroes of the arena, you might have seen the Emperor Commodus fighting as a gladiator. Think about it—the leader of Rome fighting for his life! Gladiators were admired for their bravery. Their daring deeds gripped the public's imagination, and Commodus wanted to be admired in the same way. Although he wanted to fight like a gladiator, he didn't want to die like one. He boasted that he had beaten 12,000 opponents, fighting some 735 times without getting hurt.

GLADIATORS FOUGHT ONE-ON-ONE, AS SHOWN IN THIS MODERN REENACTMENT.

